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The atmosphere at the T2 international arrival gate of Chennai Airport was charged with anticipation. Fans adjusted their banners and flags, media crews fine-tuned their cameras, and the crowd paced anxiously, all awaiting the arrival of their hero, D. Gukesh. The chess prodigy, who had etched his name in history as the youngest World Chess Champion after dethroning Ding Liren of China in a gruelling 14-game match in Singapore, was returning home to a hero's welcome.

By 7:30 am, people had begun queuing to catch a glimpse of Gukesh. By 10:30, impatience had set in. Yet when the young champion finally emerged, the wait proved worthwhile. Gukesh made a grand entry, adorned with a crown, a massive garland, and wrapped in the Indian flag, proudly holding the gleaming World Championship trophy.

Just as it seemed the homecoming would go smoothly, the scene unravelled. **Chaos erupted, echoing the overwhelming and borderline intrusive receptions that Gukesh and R. Praggnanandhaa had experienced following their historic Candidates and World Cup triumphs.** History, it appeared, was repeating itself.

The combined efforts of airport management, local police, members of the Sports Development Authority of Tamil Nadu (SDAT), and the All India Chess Federation (AICF) proved insufficient to control the frenzied crowd eager to catch a glimpse of their hero. The local press stood out, notorious for pushing boundaries in their quest for an elusive soundbite

or photo from their celebrity subject.

At first glance, the scene resembled the aftermath of a stampede. People rushed in all directions, with bracelets, slippers, and shoes littering the floor — tangible evidence of utter chaos, with no one seemingly in control.

At the centre of it all stood Gukesh, one of the most humble athletes — not just in chess, but across any sport. Despite the bedlam, he graciously obliged every request for autographs and selfies, embodying patience and humility.

Amid the pandemonium, one striking image stood out: Gukesh's father, Dr Rajnikanth, desperately trying to assist his son but unable to navigate the commotion.

Gukesh could have arrived in quieter circumstances. Knowing his humility, he would have patiently answered every question, posed for every selfie, and signed every autograph. Yet inside the airport, where *Sportstar* managed to steal a glimpse, the chaos was no different — another telling moment of how we celebrate our heroes.

Amid the hysteria, there was also a heartwarming side to the story. Among the hundreds of fans, there was Gomathi, an athletics coach with SDAT, who led a group of 30 boys and nearly as many girls from various sports disciplines under SDAT's banner.

"We're extremely proud of Gukesh's achievement. He hasn't just won the World Championship but has also become the youngest to do so. It feels as though one of our own dreams has come true. This victory feels very personal," said

Gomathi, reflecting on the historic moment.

She added, "Today, we celebrate one Gukesh, but I hope to see many more 'Gukeshs' in the future. This victory can serve as a stepping stone."

Rahul Kamble from Karnataka travelled nearly 850 kilometres from Belgaum to Chennai to see his champion.

"I came here to meet Gukesh. He shook hands with me, and that moment was worth everything. I've been on the road cycling since November 25, supporting Gukesh. Along the way, I visited several chess academies. My dream is to take a photo with Gukesh and my cycle. From here, I plan to travel across Tamil Nadu," shared Rahul, whose journey paralleled Gukesh's World Championship campaign.

A chess trainer at a private school in his hometown, Rahul's commitment to his journey cost him his job. **His school management denied him permission for his cycling tour, but he chose to quit and pursue it anyway.**

"I travelled up north to Goa and then towards Mumbai during the Candidates Tournament, and Gukesh won that. A friend told me I had to continue my journey to bring Gukesh luck, so I quit my job.

Hopefully, I'll get the chance to tell him my story."

« Adorned with a crown, a garland, and wrapped in the Tricolour, Gukesh made a grand entry »

